

Notes: Lee, Moretti, and Butler (QJE, 2004)

Do Voters Affect or Elect Policies? Evidence from the U.S. House

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1 Big picture

- **Question.** Do voters *affect* politicians' policy choices by forcing candidates to moderate, or do voters merely *elect* between politicians whose policy positions are essentially fixed?
- **Core contrast.** The paper distinguishes two views of electoral competition:
 - **Downsian/partial convergence:** politicians respond to electoral pressure; stronger electoral prospects allow more partisan policy choices, while weaker prospects induce moderation.
 - **Full divergence/credibility problem:** candidates cannot credibly commit to moderation, so election outcomes select which candidate's preferred policy is implemented.
- **Empirical setting.** U.S. House elections from 1946-1995, linked to roll-call voting measures. The House is a useful setting because elections are frequent, votes are public, and Democrats and Republicans have distinct policy positions.
- **Identification idea.** Close elections create quasi-random variation in which party holds the seat. If Democrats barely win instead of barely lose, the Democratic Party receives a large incumbency advantage in the next election.
- **Key experiment.** Compare future roll-call voting in districts where a Democrat barely won at time t with districts where a Democrat barely lost at time t .
- **Decomposition.** A close Democratic win at t affects future voting at $t + 1$ in two possible ways:
 - **Elect component:** the Democratic win makes it more likely that a Democrat will win at $t + 1$, and Democrats vote more liberally than Republicans.
 - **Affect component:** the Democratic win changes the intended policy positions of candidates at $t + 1$ by changing their electoral strength.
- **Main result.** The total effect of a close Democratic win on future ADA scores is about 21 ADA points. The estimated elect component is about 22.8 points. The residual affect component is about -1.6 points, statistically indistinguishable from zero.
- **Interpretation.** Voters primarily *elect* policies rather than *affect* policy choices in U.S. House general elections.
- **Robustness.** The same result holds with DW-NOMINATE scores, party-leadership voting, liberal and conservative interest-group ratings, decade splits, balance tests, placebo pre-treatment voting outcomes, and a more flexible heterogeneity framework.
- **Takeaway.** Electoral competition in the general election does not appear to induce meaningful policy moderation. The credibility problem emphasized by Alesina-style models dominates the Downsian moderation channel in this setting.

2 Data and measurement

2.1 Unit of observation and election timing

- The unit of observation is a district-congressional session.
- Time t denotes an electoral cycle: the campaign, the November election, and the congressional session following that election.
- Time $t + 1$ denotes the next electoral cycle and congressional session.
- Example: if t is the 1992 election, the corresponding congressional session is 1993-1994; $t + 1$ is the 1994 election and 1995-1996 session.
- The main empirical analysis uses pairs of adjacent election cycles from 1946 to 1995, excluding periods where redistricting prevents clean district linking.

Interpretation: The timing is essential. The paper does not simply ask whether Democrats vote differently from Republicans. It asks whether a quasi-random Democratic win at t changes future voting at $t + 1$ through electoral strength.

2.2 Election data

- The election data come mainly from ICPSR Study 6311, *Elections to the United States House of Representatives, 1898-1992*, compiled by Gary King.
- The dataset reports state, district, incumbency status, and total votes received by Democratic and Republican candidates.
- King classifies races as normal two-party elections or exceptions. The paper drops exceptions, such as races with important independent candidates.
- The 1994 election data are obtained from the U.S. House of Representatives Office of the Clerk.
- The key running variable is Democratic two-party vote share in election t .
- The key treatment is

$$D_t = 1\{\text{Democrat wins election } t\},$$

which switches discontinuously when Democratic vote share crosses 50 percent.

Interpretation: The regression discontinuity design is built around the discontinuity at exactly 50 percent of the two-party vote. Bare winners and bare losers should be comparable except for which party holds the seat.

2.3 Main roll-call voting outcome: ADA scores

- The preferred voting record measure is the adjusted Americans for Democratic Action (ADA) score.
- ADA scores range from 0 to 100.
- Higher ADA scores indicate more liberal roll-call voting.
- The ADA selects roughly twenty high-profile roll-call votes per Congress and constructs a voting index for each representative.
- The paper uses adjusted ADA scores to make comparisons across congressional sessions meaningful.

Interpretation: The ADA score is the main policy outcome: a large jump in ADA scores means the district's future representative votes more liberally.

2.4 Alternative roll-call measures

- **DW-NOMINATE scores:** ideological scores based on all roll-call votes, not a selected subset. Higher first-dimension scores correspond to more conservative voting.
- **Party-leadership loyalty:** the percentage of a representative's votes that agree with the Democratic party leader.
- **Interest-group ratings:** liberal and conservative ratings from organizations such as the ACLU, League of Conservation Voters, AFL-CIO-related groups, Conservative Coalition, U.S. Chamber of Commerce, American Conservative Union, and Christian Voice.

Interpretation: Robustness across alternative voting measures is important because the ADA score uses a selected subset of votes. The result should not depend on one ideological index.

2.5 Close-election sample

- The main close-election sample includes observations with Democratic vote share strictly between 48 percent and 52 percent.
- This window contains 915 district-session observations in the main ADA analysis.
- The average number of close races per year is around forty, with variation across congressional sessions.
- The close-election sample provides the local randomization used to estimate the causal effect of party incumbency.

Interpretation: The analysis trades sample size for identification strength. The closer the race, the more plausible that the winner is effectively random.

3 Model, parameters, and empirical specifications

3.1 Conceptual model: affect versus elect

Let x_t denote the Democratic candidate’s policy position and y_t denote the Republican candidate’s policy position. Let D_t indicate that the Democrat wins. The observed roll-call record is

$$RC_t = (1 - D_t)y_t + D_t x_t. \quad (1)$$

Interpretation: Only the winning candidate’s policy is observed. The central difficulty is that the losing candidate’s intended policy is unobserved.

3.2 Reduced-form roll-call representation

The paper motivates the following representation:

$$RC_t = \text{constant} + \pi_0 P_t^* + \pi_1 D_t + \varepsilon_t, \quad (2)$$

$$RC_{t+1} = \text{constant} + \pi_0 P_{t+1}^* + \pi_1 D_{t+1} + \varepsilon_{t+1}. \quad (3)$$

- P_t^* is the underlying electoral strength of the Democratic Party at fixed platforms.
- π_0 measures how candidates’ policy choices respond to electoral strength.
- π_1 is the party effect: the difference between Democratic and Republican policy positions.
- ε_t captures district-level heterogeneity in policy positions.

Interpretation: Partial convergence corresponds to $\pi_0 > 0$: candidates move when electoral strength changes. Full divergence corresponds to $\pi_0 = 0$: electoral strength does not affect intended policy.

3.3 Total effect

If close elections make D_t as good as randomly assigned, then

$$\begin{aligned} \gamma &= E[RC_{t+1} \mid D_t = 1] - E[RC_{t+1} \mid D_t = 0] \\ &= \pi_0(P_{t+1}^{*D} - P_{t+1}^{*R}) + \pi_1(P_{t+1}^D - P_{t+1}^R). \end{aligned} \quad (4)$$

Interpretation: The total RD jump in future roll-call scores, γ , is not by itself the affect effect. It combines candidate moderation with the higher probability that the next representative is a Democrat.

3.4 Elect component

The party effect is estimated from the contemporaneous roll-call discontinuity:

$$E[RC_t \mid D_t = 1] - E[RC_t \mid D_t = 0] = \pi_1. \quad (5)$$

The future probability effect is estimated from

$$E[D_{t+1} \mid D_t = 1] - E[D_{t+1} \mid D_t = 0] = P_{t+1}^D - P_{t+1}^R. \quad (6)$$

Thus the elect component is

$$\text{Elect} = \pi_1(P_{t+1}^D - P_{t+1}^R). \quad (7)$$

Interpretation: This is the channel through which voters choose which party’s policy is implemented. A close Democratic win today increases the probability of a Democratic win next time, and Democrats vote more liberally.

3.5 Affect component

The affect component is the residual:

$$\text{Affect} = \gamma - \pi_1(P_{t+1}^D - P_{t+1}^R) = \pi_0(P_{t+1}^{*D} - P_{t+1}^{*R}). \quad (8)$$

Interpretation: This is the object that distinguishes partial convergence from full divergence. If electoral competition moderates policy, the residual should be meaningfully positive. The paper estimates it near zero.

3.6 Regression-discontinuity implementation

Graphically, the paper estimates discontinuities around the 50 percent Democratic vote-share threshold. The plotted fitted values use fourth-order polynomials in vote share on either side of the threshold, with a jump at 50 percent.

For the main tables, the authors use a simple close-election comparison:

$$\widehat{\Delta Y} = \bar{Y}(50\% < VS_t < 52\%) - \bar{Y}(48\% < VS_t < 50\%). \quad (9)$$

Interpretation: The local-window estimator is easy to read: compare barely Democratic districts with barely Republican districts.

4 Identification and empirical design

4.1 Main identifying assumption

- Among elections decided by a very small margin, the winning party is as good as randomly assigned.
- The intuition is that unpredictable vote-count and turnout shocks determine who barely crosses the 50 percent threshold.
- Therefore, districts where Democrats barely win and barely lose should have similar voters, candidates, resources, and baseline policy preferences.

Interpretation: This is a local randomization argument. It does not claim all Democratic and Republican districts are comparable; it claims very close winners and losers are comparable.

4.2 Balance tests

The paper checks whether predetermined district characteristics change discontinuously at the 50 percent threshold:

- region indicators: North, South, West;
- log income;
- high-school graduation share;
- urban share;
- black population share;
- manufacturing employment;
- total population;
- eligible-to-vote share;
- open-seat indicator.

Interpretation: Balance matters because a discontinuity in district covariates would imply close Democratic and Republican winners are not comparable. The paper finds no meaningful discontinuity in the narrow windows and polynomial RD estimate.

4.3 Placebo test using past voting records

The paper checks whether ADA scores in earlier congressional sessions, $t - 1$ and $t - 2$, jump at the time- t election threshold.

Interpretation: A valid design should not show a discontinuity in past voting behavior. Figure V supports this: the estimated gap is small and statistically weak.

4.4 Why estimating π_1 alone is insufficient

Many studies show that Democrats and Republicans vote differently. That rejects complete convergence but does not distinguish partial convergence from full divergence.

Interpretation: The innovation of this paper is the decomposition. It asks not simply whether party matters, but whether electoral strength changes policy positions after accounting for party selection.

4.5 Potential concerns and paper responses

- **District heterogeneity:** Bliss-point gaps may differ by district. The paper’s heterogeneity exercise divides close elections into top, middle, and bottom groups based on next-election outcomes and vote shares.
- **Functional form:** The graphical RD uses flexible polynomials, while the tables use a narrow close-election window.
- **Alternative ideology measures:** Results hold using DW-NOMINATE, party-leadership voting, and interest-group ratings.
- **Time variation:** Results hold by decade, though the size of the total/elect effect changes over time.
- **Redistricting:** Adjacent-cycle pairs that cannot be linked due to redistricting are excluded.

Interpretation: The design is strongest for the local statement around close House elections. It does not prove that elections never shape candidate selection, primary outcomes, or party platforms.

5 Section-by-section detailed roadmap

5.1 Section I: Introduction

- Introduces the central distinction between voters affecting policy and voters electing policy.
- Explains why Downsian convergence requires credible commitments to moderate positions.
- Motivates the empirical test: look at whether an exogenous increase in electoral strength changes roll-call voting behavior.
- States the main finding: electoral strength does not affect voting behavior after accounting for which party is elected.

5.2 Section II: Conceptual background and identification strategy

- Reviews the Downsian paradigm and the Alesina credibility problem.
- Defines the empirical thought experiment: randomly assign which party wins at time t , then observe how this changes the party's electoral strength at $t + 1$.
- Explains that the observed total effect is the sum of an elect component and an affect component.
- Uses close elections as the practical approximation to the randomized experiment.

5.3 Section III: Econometric framework

- Formalizes the observed roll-call equation.
- Defines the parameters π_0 and π_1 .
- Shows how the total effect, elect component, and affect component are identified under local random assignment.
- Derives why γ alone is insufficient: it combines party selection and candidate-policy response.

5.4 Section IV: Roll-call voting records and data

- Explains why the U.S. House is a good test case: two-party structure, frequent elections, public voting, and visible party differences.
- Defines adjusted ADA scores and motivates their use.
- Discusses alternative outcomes: DW-NOMINATE, party leadership voting, and interest-group ratings.
- Describes the election and roll-call data sources.

5.5 Section V.A: Main empirical results

- Shows the main RD figures and Table I.
- Finds a total effect of 21.2 ADA points.
- Finds a party-effect estimate of 47.6 ADA points and a future Democratic win probability difference of 0.48.

- Their product is an elect component of 22.84 points.
- The affect component is $21.2 - 22.84 = -1.64$, essentially zero.

5.6 Section V.B: Evidence for RD validity

- Figures III and IV show smooth predetermined district characteristics around the close-election threshold.
- Table II quantifies balance in wider and narrower windows.
- Figure V checks past voting records and finds no meaningful discontinuity.

5.7 Section V.C: Alternative voting records

- Table III repeats the decomposition with DW-NOMINATE and party-leadership voting.
- Figure VI gives the graphical version for these alternative measures.
- Figures VII-XI summarize and display robustness using many liberal and conservative interest-group ratings.
- The same pattern emerges: the total effect lines up with the elect component, and the affect component is small.

5.8 Section V.D: Heterogeneity

- A key concern is that the gap between Democratic and Republican bliss points may differ across districts and over time.
- Table IV shows results by decade.
- Table V implements a more general heterogeneity framework using close-election subgroups.
- In the top and bottom groups, where the test targets successful challengers, the differences are near zero; in the middle group, where party selection is central, the difference is large.

5.9 Section VI: Relation to the literature

- Distinguishes this paper from prior work showing party differences in roll-call voting.
- Prior evidence against complete convergence does not answer whether electoral pressure induces partial convergence.
- The paper argues that representation across constituencies may come from candidate selection, party nomination, or district-level sorting rather than general-election moderation.

5.10 Section VII and appendices

- Concludes that voters primarily elect policies in U.S. House general elections.
- Appendix 1 derives the reduced-form equations and the close-election random-assignment argument.
- Appendix 2 documents data sources, including election data, ADA scores, roll-call records, NOMINATE data, and district covariates.

6 Figures and tables

6.1 Figure I and Figure II: total effect and its two components

Read:

- Figure I shows a sharp jump in future ADA scores at the 50 percent Democratic vote-share threshold.
- The discontinuity is the total effect γ .
- Figure IIa shows the party-affiliation discontinuity, π_1 : Democrats and Republicans have very different ADA scores.
- Figure IIb shows the incumbency/election-probability discontinuity: a close Democratic win at t strongly raises the probability of a Democratic win at $t + 1$.

Economic message: The total effect is visually large, but the components show that it arises from selecting a different party into office rather than moving candidates' intended policies.

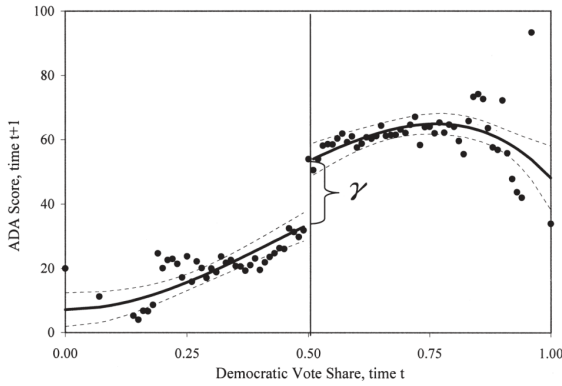


FIGURE I
Total Effect of Initial Win on Future ADA Scores: γ
This figure plots ADA scores after the election at time $t + 1$ against the Democrat vote share, time t . Each circle is the average ADA score within 0.01 intervals of the Democrat vote share. Solid lines are fitted values from fourth-order polynomial regressions on either side of the discontinuity. Dotted lines are pointwise 95 percent confidence intervals. The discontinuity gap estimates

$$\gamma = \underbrace{\pi_0(P_{t+1}^{DD} - P_{t+1}^{RR})}_{\text{"Affect"}} + \underbrace{\pi_1(P_{t+1}^{DD} - P_{t+1}^{RR})}_{\text{"Elect"}}$$

Figure I: total effect on future ADA scores

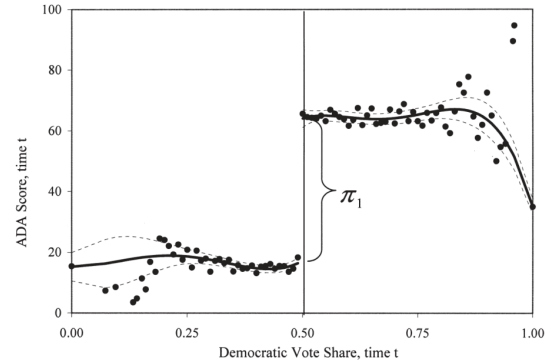


FIGURE IIa
Effect of Party Affiliation: π_1

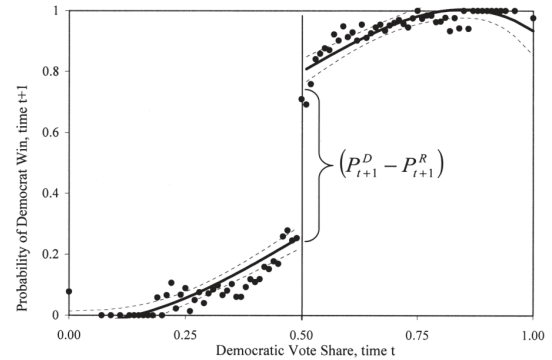


FIGURE IIb
Effect of Initial Win on Winning Next Election: $(P_{t+1}^D - P_{t+1}^R)$
Top panel plots ADA scores after the election at time $t + 1$ against the Democrat vote share, time t . Bottom panel plots probability of Democrat victory at $t + 1$ against Democrat vote share, time t . See caption of Figure III for more details.

Figure II: party effect and next-election win-probability effect

6.2 Table I: main decomposition with ADA scores

Read:

- Total effect: $\gamma = 21.2$ ADA points.
- Party effect: $\pi_1 = 47.6$ ADA points.
- Difference in future Democratic win probabilities: 0.48.
- Elect component: $47.6 \times 0.48 = 22.84$ ADA points.
- Affect component: $21.2 - 22.84 = -1.64$ ADA points.
- Sample size: 915 close-election observations.

Economic message: The entire future ADA jump is explained by the fact that a close Democratic win makes a future Democratic representative more likely. The candidate-moderation channel is essentially zero.

TABLE I
RESULTS BASED ON ADA SCORES—CLOSE ELECTIONS SAMPLE

Variable	Total effect			Elect component	Affect component
	γ	π_1	$(P_{t+1}^D - P_{t+1}^R)$	$\pi_1[P_{t+1}^D - P_{t+1}^R]$	$\pi_0[P_{t+1}^D - P_{t+1}^R]$
	ADA_{t+1}	ADA_t	DEM_{t+1}	(col. (2))(col. (3))	(col. (1)) - (col. (4))
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Estimated gap	21.2 (1.9)	47.6 (1.3)	0.48 (0.02)	22.84 (2.2)	-1.64 (2.0)

Standard errors are in parentheses. The unit of observation is a district-congressional session. The sample includes only observations where the Democrat vote share at time t is strictly between 48 percent and 52 percent. The estimated gap is the difference in the average of the relevant variable for observations for which the Democrat vote share at time t is strictly between 50 percent and 52 percent and observations for which the Democrat vote share at time t is strictly between 48 percent and 50 percent. Time t and $t + 1$ refer to congressional sessions. ADA_t is the adjusted ADA voting score. Higher ADA scores correspond to more liberal roll-call voting records. Sample size is 915.

Table I: ADA decomposition in the close-election sample

6.3 Figures III-IV and Table II: balance and RD validity

Read:

- Figures III and IV plot predetermined district characteristics around the close-election threshold.
- The characteristics do not show large discontinuities at 50 percent.
- Table II quantifies balance in windows from the full sample down to ± 2 percentage points.
- In narrow windows and polynomial RD specifications, most differences become small and statistically weak.

Economic message: The balance evidence supports the local randomization claim: barely Democratic and barely Republican districts are comparable around the threshold.

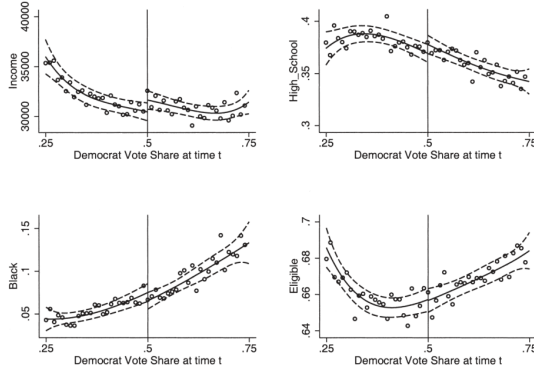


FIGURE III

Similarity of Constituents' Characteristics in Bare Democrat and Republican Districts—Part 1

Panels refer to (from top left to bottom right) the following district characteristics: real income, percentage with high-school degree, percentage black, percentage eligible to vote. Circles represent the average characteristic within intervals of 0.01 in Democrat vote share. The continuous line represents the predicted values from a fourth-order polynomial in vote share fitted separately for points above and below the 50 percent threshold. The dotted line represents the 95 percent confidence interval.

Figure III: covariate balance, part 1

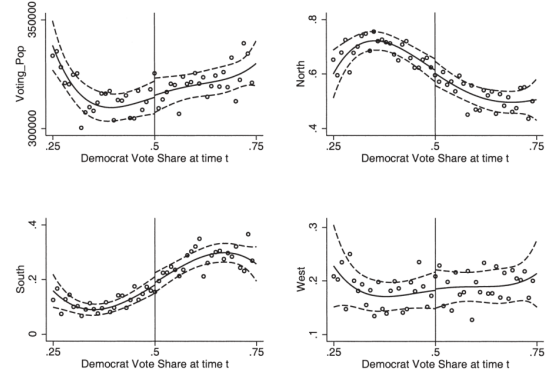


FIGURE IV

Similarity of Constituents' Characteristics in Bare Democrat and Republican Districts—Part 2

Panels refer to (from top left to bottom right) the following district characteristics: voting population, North, South, West. Circles represent the average characteristic within intervals of 0.01 in Democrat vote share. The continuous line represents the predicted values from a fourth-order polynomial in vote share fitted separately for points above and below the 50 percent threshold. The dotted line represents the 95 percent confidence interval.

Figure IV: covariate balance, part 2

TABLE II
DIFFERENCE IN DISTRICT CHARACTERISTICS BETWEEN DEMOCRAT AND REPUBLICAN DISTRICTS, BY DISTANCE FROM 50 PERCENT

	All	+/- 25	+/- 10	+/- 5	+/- 2	Polynomial
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
North	-0.211 (0.018)	-0.156 (0.019)	-0.096 (0.021)	-0.054 (0.024)	-0.059 (0.036)	-0.041 (0.045)
South	0.250 (0.015)	0.145 (0.014)	0.093 (0.016)	0.053 (0.019)	0.009 (0.028)	0.015 (0.036)
West	-0.031 (0.013)	-0.012 (0.015)	-0.036 (0.020)	-0.003 (0.017)	0.001 (0.020)	0.001 (0.036)
Log income	-0.086 (0.013)	-0.036 (0.012)	0.014 (0.014)	0.026 (0.017)	0.030 (0.026)	0.052 (0.033)
Percentage high-school grad.	-0.035 (0.003)	-0.024 (0.003)	-0.008 (0.004)	-0.001 (0.004)	0.001 (0.007)	0.008 (0.008)
Percentage urban	0.070 (0.011)	0.065 (0.011)	0.053 (0.012)	0.053 (0.014)	0.056 (0.023)	0.053 (0.028)
Percentage black	0.082 (0.005)	0.042 (0.004)	0.013 (0.004)	0.003 (0.005)	-0.003 (0.009)	-0.053 (0.013)
Manufacturing employment	-0.002 (0.001)	0.000 (0.001)	0.004 (0.002)	0.004 (0.002)	0.005 (0.004)	0.003 (0.005)
Total population	-1817.9 (3517.3)	3019.2 (3723.0)	4961.5 (4562.4)	3211.4 (5524.2)	8640.4 (8427.9)	2007.5 (10483.0)
Percentage eligible to vote	0.005 (0.002)	0.010 (0.002)	0.007 (0.003)	0.006 (0.004)	-0.003 (0.006)	-0.003 (0.007)
Open seats	0.070 (0.011)	0.065 (0.011)	0.053 (0.012)	0.053 (0.014)	0.056 (0.023)	0.053 (0.028)
Number of observations	13413	10229	4174	2072	910	13413

Standard errors are in parentheses. The unit of observation is a district-congressional session. Columns (1) to (5) report the difference in average district characteristics between Democrat and Republican districts. Column (1) includes the entire sample. Columns (2) to (5) include only districts with Democrat vote share between 25 percent and 75 percent, 40 percent and 60 percent, 45 percent and 55 percent, and 48 percent and 52 percent, respectively. The model in column (6) includes a fourth-order polynomial in Democrat vote share that enters separately for vote share above and below 50 percent. The coefficient reported in column (6) is the predicted difference at 50 percent. All standard errors account for district-decade clustering.

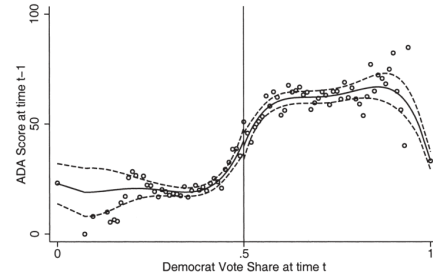


FIGURE V

Specification Test: Similarity of Historical Voting Patterns between Bare Democrat and Republican Districts

The panel plots one time lagged ADA scores against the Democrat vote share. Time t and $t - 1$ refer to congressional sessions. Each point is the average lagged ADA score within intervals of 0.01 in Democrat vote share. The continuous line is from a fourth-order polynomial in vote share fitted separately for points above and below the 50 percent threshold. The dotted line is the 95 percent confidence interval.

6.4 Figure V: placebo test using historical voting records

Read:

- Figure V uses ADA scores from congressional sessions before the election at time t .
- If the RD design is valid, past voting should not jump at the future close-election threshold.
- The figure shows no economically meaningful discontinuity in prior ADA scores.

Economic message: This placebo test rules out the idea that barely Democratic districts already had sharply different prior roll-call patterns.

6.5 Table III and Figure VI: alternative ideology measures

Read:

- With DW-NOMINATE scores, the total effect is -0.36 , the elect component is -0.34 , and the affect component is -0.02 .
- With party-leadership voting, the total effect is 0.13 , the elect component is 0.13 , and the affect component is 0.00 .
- Figure VI provides the graphical analog for these alternative outcomes.

Economic message: The result is not an ADA-score artifact. Alternative roll-call measures again imply that voters elect policies rather than alter candidates' policy choices.

TABLE III
RESULTS BASED ON NOMINATE SCORES AND ON PERCENT VOTED LIKE DEMOCRAT
LEADERSHIP—CLOSE ELECTIONS SAMPLE

Variable	Total effect		Elect component		Affect component
	γ Z_{t+1} (1)	π_1 Z_t (2)	$(P_{t+1}^D - P_{t+1}^R)$ DEM_{t+1} (3)	$\pi_1[(P_{t+1}^D - P_{t+1}^R)]$ (col. (2)*(col. (3))) (4)	$\pi_0(P_{t+1}^D - P_{t+1}^R)$ (col. (1)) - (col. (4)) (5)
(a) Results based on Nominate scores					
Estimated gap	-0.36 (0.03)	-0.58 (0.02)	0.62 (0.04)	-0.34 (0.04)	-0.02 (0.04)
(b) Results based on percent voted like Democrat leadership					
Estimated gap	0.13 (0.01)	0.29 (0.006)	0.46 (0.02)	0.13 (0.02)	0.00 (0.02)

Standard errors are in parentheses. The unit of observation is a district-congressional session. The sample includes only observations where the Democrat vote share at time t is strictly between 48 percent and 52 percent. The estimated gap is the difference in the relevant variable for observations for which the Democrat vote share at time t is strictly between 50 percent and 52 percent and observations for which the Democrat vote share at time t is strictly between 48 percent and 50 percent. Time t and $t + 1$ refer to congressional sessions. The top panel uses the DW-NOMINATE score constructed by McCarty, Poole, and Rosenthal. Higher Nominate scores correspond to more conservative roll-call voting records. The bottom panel uses the percent of a representative's votes that agree with the Democrat party leader. Sample size is 276 in top panel and 1010 in bottom panel.

Table III: NOMINATE and leadership voting

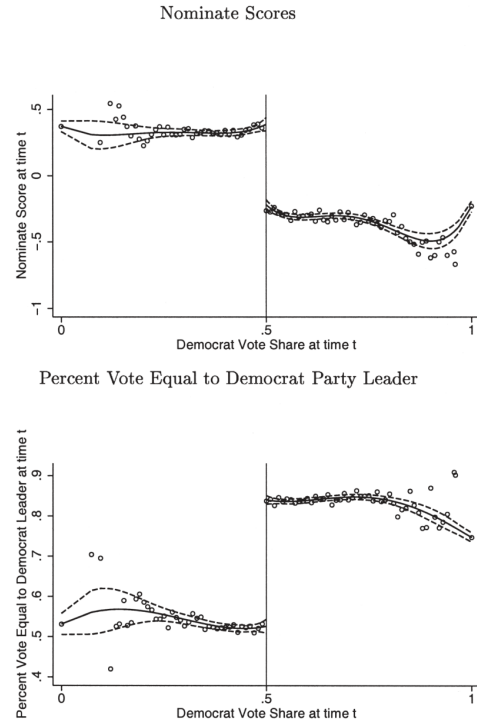


FIGURE VI
Nominate Scores, by Democrat Vote Share; and Percent Voted with Democrat Leader, by Democrat Vote Share

The top panel plots DW-Nominate scores at time t against the Democrat vote share at time t . Circles represent the average Nominate score within intervals of 0.01 in Democrat vote share. The bottom panel plots the fraction of a Representative's votes that agree with the Democrat party leader at time t against the Democrat vote share at time t . Circles represent the percent voted with Democrat leader within intervals of 0.01 in Democrat vote share. The continuous line is from a fourth-order polynomial in vote share fitted separately for points above and below the 50 percent threshold. The dotted line is the 95 percent confidence interval.

Figure VI: alternative voting measures

6.6 Figures VII-XI: liberal and conservative interest-group ratings

Read:

- Figure VII plots the total effect against the elect component across alternative interest-group ratings.
- The estimates cluster near the 45-degree line, indicating that total effects are explained by the elect channel.
- Figures VIII and IX display liberal group ratings around the threshold.

- Figures X and XI display conservative group ratings around the threshold.
- These graphs show the same discontinuity pattern as ADA and NOMINATE outcomes.

Economic message: Across many policy domains, the close-election effect operates through party selection rather than candidate moderation.

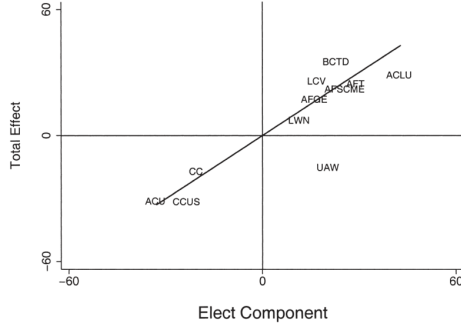


FIGURE VII
Total Effect $[\gamma]$ Versus "Elect Policy" Component $[\pi_1(P_{t+1}^D - P_{t+1}^R)]$, for Alternative Interest Group Ratings

The figure plots estimates of the Total Effect $[\gamma]$ on the y-axis against estimates of the "Elect Policy" component $[\pi_1(P_{t+1}^D - P_{t+1}^R)]$ on the x-axis for eleven interest groups ratings. The line is the 45° line. The closer the total effect is to the "elect component" effect for an interest group, the closer that group symbol is to the 45° line. All ratings are between 0 and 100. Higher ratings of liberal interest groups correspond to more liberal roll-call voting records. Higher ratings of conservative interest groups correspond to more conservative roll-call voting records.

ACLU is America Civil Liberties Union; LWV is League of Women Voters; LCV is League of Conservation Voters; AFGE is American Federal Government Employees; AFSCME is American Federation State, County, Municipal Employees; AFT is American Federation of Teachers; BCTD is AFL-CIO Building and Construction; UAW is United Auto Workers; CC is Conservative Coalition; CCUS is U. S. Chamber of Commerce; ACU is American Conservative Union.

Figure VII: total effect versus elect component

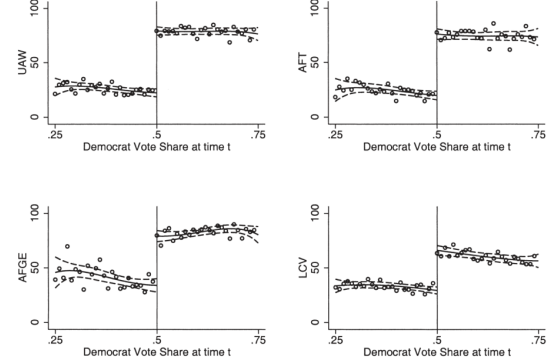


FIGURE VIII
Liberal Interest Groups Ratings, by Democrat Vote Share—Part 1

The top panel on the left refers to ratings from United Auto Workers. The top panel on the right refers to ratings from American Federation of Teachers. The bottom panel on the left refers to ratings from American Federation of Government Employees. The bottom panel on the right refers to ratings from League of Conservative Voters. Circles represent average ratings within intervals of 0.01 in Democrat vote share. The continuous line is from a fourth-order polynomial in vote share fitted separately for points above and below the 50 percent threshold. The dotted line is the 95 percent confidence interval.

Figure VIII: liberal interest-group ratings, part 1

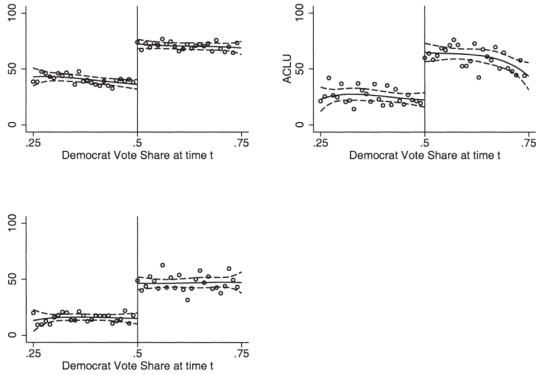


FIGURE IX
Liberal Interest Groups Ratings, by Democrat Vote Share—Part 2
The top panel on the left refers to ratings from League of Women Voters. The top panel on the right refers to ratings from American Civil Liberties Union. The bottom panel on the left refers to ratings from Taxation with Representation. Circles represent average ratings within intervals of 0.01 in Democrat vote share. The continuous line is from a fourth-order polynomial in vote share fitted separately for points above and below the 50 percent threshold. The dotted line is the 95 percent confidence interval.

Figure IX: liberal interest-group ratings, part 2

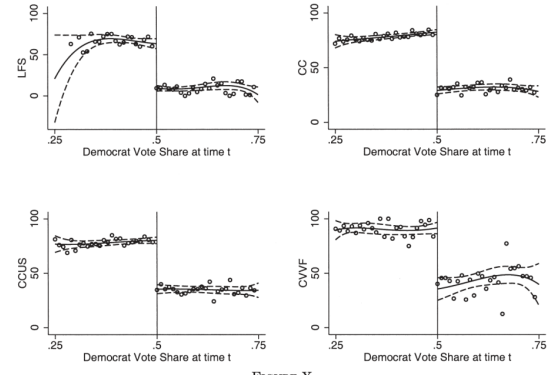


FIGURE X
Conservative Interest Groups Ratings, by Democrat Vote Share—Part 1
The top panel on the left refers to ratings from the Lower Federal Spending Support Score. The top panel on the right refers to ratings from the Conservative Coalition. The bottom panel on the left refers to ratings from the Chamber of Commerce. The bottom panel on the right refers to ratings from the Christian Voters Victory Fund. Circles represent average ratings within intervals of 0.01 in Democrat vote share. The continuous line is from a fourth-order polynomial in vote share fitted separately for points above and below the 50 percent threshold. The dotted line is the 95 percent confidence interval.

Figure X: conservative interest-group ratings, part 1

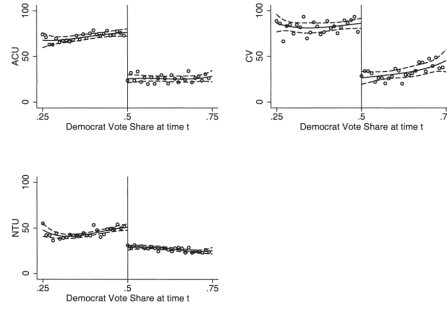


FIGURE XI
Conservative Interest Groups Ratings, by Democrat Vote Share—Part 2
The top panel on the left refers to ratings from the American Conservative Union. The top panel on the right refers to ratings from the Christian Voice. The bottom panel on the left refers to ratings from the National Taxpayers' Union. Circles represent average ratings within intervals of 0.01 in Democrat vote share. The continuous line is from a fourth-order polynomial in vote share fitted separately for points above and below the 50 percent threshold. The dotted line is the 95 percent confidence interval.

Figure XI: conservative interest-group ratings, part 2

6.7 Table IV and Table V: decade splits and heterogeneity

Read: Table IV:

- The decomposition is repeated by decade.
- In 1946-1958, the affect component is -2.8 .
- In 1960-1968, the affect component is -1.7 .
- In 1970-1978, the affect component is -7.1 .
- In 1980-1996, the affect component is 3.8 .
- None of these estimates gives strong evidence of meaningful policy moderation.

Read: Table V:

- Among close Republican-held districts, Democrats win the next election 24.1 percent of the time.
- Among close Democratic-held districts, Democrats win the next election 72.6 percent of the time.
- In the top group, the difference in average ADA is -1.7 .
- In the middle group, the difference is 47.4, reflecting party selection.
- In the bottom group, the difference is -4.6 .

Economic message: Even under a more flexible heterogeneity framework, the estimated candidate-response effect remains near zero.

TABLE IV
RESULTS BASED ON ADA SCORES, BY DECADE—CLOSE ELECTIONS SAMPLE

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
	Total effect			Elect component	
	γ	π_1	$(P_{t+1}^{D_1} - P_{t+1}^{R_1})$	$\pi_1[(P_{t+1}^{D_1} - P_{t+1}^{R_1})]$	$\pi_0[(P_{t+1}^{D_1} - P_{t+1}^{R_1})]$
Variable	ADA_{t+1}	ADA_t	DEM_{t+1}	(col. (2))/(col. (3))	(col. (1)) - (col. (4))
1946–1958	14.2 (3.2)	41.7 (2.3)	0.41 (0.05)	17.0 (4.8)	-2.8 (4.0)
1960–1968	23.5 (3.5)	49.5 (2.7)	0.51 (0.05)	25.2 (4.9)	-1.7 (4.1)
1970–1978	11.5 (4.7)	46.6 (3.1)	0.40 (0.06)	18.6 (5.1)	-7.1 (5.1)
1980–1996	46.8 (3.7)	56.6 (2.8)	0.76 (0.05)	43.0 (4.9)	3.8 (4.5)

Standard errors are in parentheses. The unit of observation is a district-congressional session. The sample includes only observations where the Democrat vote share at time t is strictly between 48 percent and 52 percent. The estimated gap is the difference in the average of the relevant variable for observations for which the Democrat vote share at time t is strictly between 50 percent and 52 percent and observations for which the Democrat vote share at time t is strictly between 48 percent and 50 percent. Time t and $t + 1$ refer to congressional sessions. ADA_t is the adjusted ADA voting score. Higher ADA scores correspond to more liberal roll-call voting records. Sample sizes are 322 in 1946–1958; 245 in 1960–1968; 183 in 1970–1978; 164 in 1980–1996.

Table IV: ADA decomposition by decade

TABLE V
ADDITIONAL ESTIMATES USING ADA SCORES—CLOSE ELECTIONS SAMPLE

	Districts, where $DEM_t = 0$		Districts, where $DEM_t = 1$	
Panel A	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Percent $DEM_{t+1} = 1$	24.1	72.6		
Percent $DEM_{t+1} = 0$	75.9	27.4		
Total	100	100		
Panel B	Average ADA_{t+1} in districts, where $DEM_t = 0$	Average ADA_{t+1} in districts, where $DEM_t = 1$	Difference in average ADA_{t+1} (col. (2)) - (col. (1))	Obs.
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Districts in top group	67.6 (3.0)	65.9 (2.9)	-1.7 (3.0)	224
Districts in middle group	18.6 (1.7)	66.1 (1.8)	47.4 (1.8)	441
Districts in bottom group	21.1 (2.2)	16.5 (2.1)	-4.6 (2.3)	250

Standard errors are in parentheses. The unit of observation is a district-congressional session. The sample includes only observations where the Democrat vote share at time t is strictly between 48 percent and 52 percent. Column (1) refers to observations for which the Democrat vote share at time t is strictly between 48 percent and 50 percent. Column (2) refers to observations for which the Democrat vote share at time t is strictly between 50 percent and 52 percent. Time t and $t + 1$ refer to congressional sessions. Higher ADA scores correspond to more liberal roll-call voting records.

Table V: heterogeneity exercise

7 Short summary

- The paper asks whether voters affect policy choices or merely elect between fixed policy positions.
- The empirical design uses close U.S. House elections as a regression discontinuity around the 50 percent vote-share threshold.
- A close Democratic win at time t raises Democratic electoral strength at $t + 1$ because of incumbency advantage.
- The total future ADA score jump is about 21.2 points.
- The party effect is about 47.6 ADA points.
- The future Democratic win-probability effect is about 0.48.
- The elect component is about 22.84 points, nearly the entire total effect.
- The affect component is about -1.64 points and statistically indistinguishable from zero.
- Balance tests and placebo tests support the close-election identification strategy.
- Robustness checks using alternative voting scores, interest-group ratings, decade splits, and heterogeneity exercises preserve the main finding.
- The paper concludes that general-election competition in U.S. House elections primarily selects between policies rather than forcing candidates to moderate their intended policy choices.

8 Conclusion

8.1 Core conclusion

Lee, Moretti, and Butler conclude that voters in U.S. House general elections mainly *elect* policies rather than *affect* policies. A close Democratic win matters because it changes which party is more likely to hold the seat in the next election, not because it induces both parties' nominees to adjust their voting behavior.

8.2 Economic intuition

The intuition is that incumbency creates electoral strength, and party identity creates policy differences. A close Democratic win gives Democrats an incumbency advantage, making a Democratic representative more likely next time. Since Democrats vote more liberally than Republicans, future roll-call scores jump. But once this selection channel is accounted for, there is no residual evidence that candidates shift toward or away from the center in response to electoral strength.

8.3 Takeaway

The paper narrows the scope of the Downsian paradigm for U.S. House general elections. General elections are powerful because they determine which party's policy is implemented, but they do not appear to discipline politicians into policy compromise. This pushes attention toward candidate selection, party nomination, primaries, and institutional credibility as the places where voter preferences may enter policy formation.